cover the expenses of its own personnel, except for housing and transportation, to be provided by the Cuban army. That army in turn would be supplied with all its requirements free of charge by the Soviet Union for the next two years. The calculations were based on a figure of 100,000 soldiers in the Cuban armed forces. A proposal to make a formal decision in that regard was sent to the Central Committee on May 7.[18]

That same day Khrushchev met with the new Soviet ambassador to Havana, Aleksandr Alekseev, who had previously headed the KGB station in the Cuban capital and, unlike his predecessor career diplomat Sergei Kudriavtsev, was highly regarded by Castro. “I do not want diarchy any longer,” Khrushchev told him. “We recognize one ambassador, and the Cubans recognize another.” Khrushchev clearly wanted an ambassador who enjoyed a good rapport with Castro. Alekseev’s suggestion that he was not up to the task because he lacked economic expertise was dismissed. Khrushchev wanted a new man in the job to help turn the page on an unhappy period in Soviet-Cuban relations. He sent Alekseev to the Central Committee to help draft a letter to Castro that would spell out the new aid package offered him by Moscow.[19]

By May 11, 1962, the letter that Alekseev had worked on was ready for the Presidium’s approval and was accepted without delay. Apart from forgiving Cuba’s debt for armaments and offering a free supply of new weapons, the letter proposed economic and managerial assistance. The Soviets committed themselves to building an underground radio center and supplying five Soviet fishing vessels, to be transferred to the Cubans if they so desired. The Soviets were also prepared to help with irrigation: the head of the Soviet delegation to be dispatched to Cuba with the good news was Sharof Rashidov, the party boss of the Soviet republic of Uzbekistan, who was considered an expert in the field. He was described to Alekseev as someone who had experience in growing sugar cane and could therefore help the Cubans with their problems. Overlooked in the excitement and chaos of putting together the new “save Cuba” economic package was the fact that the Cubans had problems with selling, not producing, their sugar.[20]

The Soviet Union was making unprecedented military and financial commitments to Cuba, and the stakes were growing higher. The same letter invited Castro to visit the USSR before the end of the year. Castro’s pledge